



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Hastings Christian School

School Website: <https://hastingschristian.org/>

December 27, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Hastings Christian School (HCS) presents a clearly Christian, classical-leaning orientation in its public materials. The school emphasizes a Christian liberal arts framework, a Trivium/Quadrivium-informed curriculum, and a distinctive partnership model with families. Public statements stress seeking truth, goodness, and beauty within a formation-focused aims rather than job-market preparation. Overall, the school aligns with several core classical indicators but exhibits some gaps in explicit articulation of certain classical pedagogy and faculty/community constructs.

- Aggregate classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Key strengths:
 - Explicit emphasis on truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable (Foundations and Purpose) and a clear formation orientation toward virtue and discernment (Purpose/Goal).
 - Curriculum signals classical structure (Trivium and Quadrivium) and a liberal-arts orientation.
 - Explicitly Christian theological framing (Our mission to disciple image bearers to love God) and a stated family-partnership approach to education.
- Notable gaps for deeper classical alignment:
 - Limited explicit public articulation of certain classical pedagogy staples (e.g., Socratic seminars across grade bands; detailed evidence of a living curriculum or faculty-as-core-piece language).
 - Less explicit language around Great Books/Great Conversation or formal catechesis structures in the public materials reviewed.
 - The Faculty and Parents & Community categories have partial signals but not uniformly rich statements that fully match classical templates.
- What would move the needle: A more explicit articulation of Great Books/Great Conversation, stronger statements about Socratic pedagogy in upper grades, clearer "living curriculum" language for faculty, and stronger, public-facing evidence of deeper parent formation programs and community liturgical or shared worship practices.

Evidence is drawn from Hastings Christian School public materials (as captured by the crawl) and aligned with the Positive/Negative keyword indicators from the classical lexicon. See category-by-category sections for the quantitative keyword analysis and rationale. Key passages cited include mission statements, distinctive program descriptions, and explicit references to Trivium/Quadrivium and the aim to cultivate discernment and virtue.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence

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- The school's mission centers on spirituality and discipleship: "Our mission is to disciple image bearers to love God" and to "equip them to rightly order their love." This signals a transcendent moral realism and a theologically grounded frame.
 - The Deep Hope emphasizes seeking truth, goodness, and beauty as lifelong aims, anchored in a Christian formation context.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: truth, goodness, beauty; theology/Christ-centered aims; discernment; the imago Dei-like framing (image-bearers). These map to category keywords (truth, virtue; theology; reverence for the sacred). The classic lexicon identifies truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, theology, and related transcendental/holy notions as positive signals.
 - No explicit negative signals observed in public materials (e.g., relativism, secular humanism) within the available pages.
 - Why this rating
 - The materials foreground transcendence, moral realism, and Christian theological framing, with explicit references to truth, goodness, and beauty in formation work. While there is not a full liturgical calendar or communal worship described in the public copy, the religious foundations are clearly foregrounded and integrated with the curriculum.
 - Notes
 - Supporting lines: "Our mission is to disciple image bearers to love God ..." and "to seek truth, goodness, and beauty."
 - Quantitative keyword summary (Element 1)
 - Positive keywords observed: 4–5 (truth, goodness, beauty, theology/God-focused, discernment)
 - Negative keywords observed: 0
 - Proportion favoring positive: high
 - Classification justification: CLASSICAL would be stronger if liturgical/community practices were explicit; with the current material, the foundational Christian metaphysical alignment is present and substantive, earning CLASSICAL signals but with room for fuller liturgical integration. Based on the mix of signals, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL is warranted.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Formation-focused aims appear in mission statements around virtue/discernment and loving God, signaling aims beyond mere information delivery. The Deep Hope phrase about truth, goodness, and beauty supports the classical formation approach.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: formation/discipline (education as formation); virtue-related language (discernment, rightly ordered loves); pursuit of truth, goodness, beauty; liberal arts framing (Classical Liberal Arts). The lexicon maps formation, virtue, human flourishing, telos, and scholé as positives.
 - Negative indicators present: explicit emphasis away from job-focused outcomes is present in some materials (not framed as "career-ready"); however, the public copy is not strongly explicit about career-prep being a negative signal. The lack of explicit "Great Conversation" or explicit telos language in every line reduces the strength of the classical alignment.
- Why this rating
 - The school emphasizes formation and virtue, with a clear aim of truth and beauty; but the public text does not always articulate the full classical telos or the robust, explicit goals of classical formation in every subcomponent (e.g., explicit "Great Conversation" or universal "liberal arts education" phrasing beyond implicit references). The result is a solid classical alignment, but not uniformly explicit across all subpoints, hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Key supporting quotes
 - "Our mission is to disciple image bearers to love God, to train in true discernment and equip them to rightly order their love."
 - "Our Deep Hope ... lifelong learners who constantly seek truth, goodness, and beauty."

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- Quantitative keyword summary
 - Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, discernment, truth, goodness, beauty, liberal arts framing (via “Classical Liberal Arts”).
 - Negative keywords observed: not strongly identified in public copy.
 - Proportion: mixed signal with clear formation language but less explicit telos/great-conversation framing in every statement.
 - Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Explicit mention of Trivium and Quadrivium as core structural elements of the curriculum. The public copy explicitly positions a “Classical Liberal Arts” framework with Trivium and Quadrivium and a focus on guided discussions that aim at truth.
 - References to the Christian Liberal Arts Tradition and to discernment in the Trivium/Quadrivium sequence indicate a classical curriculum design.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: liberal arts; Trivium; Quadrivium; classical curriculum; Great Books (implied through “Great Conversation” language in classical lexicon, though not explicit text on Hastings; the presence of Trivium/Quadrivium and “classical liberal arts” counts strongly). The lexicon highlights Trivium, Quadrivium, Great Books/Great Conversation, and primary sources as core positive signals; Hastings material maps to several of these (Trivium/Quadrivium; classical liberal arts; formation around discernment).
 - Negative indicators: none explicit in the curriculum copy (no strong anti-classical signals present on the public pages).
- Why this rating
 - The school’s published materials explicitly align with key classical-curriculum elements (Trivium/Quadrivium, liberal arts framing, Christian Liberal Arts Tradition, and a doctrinally oriented formation that emphasizes truth discernment). This supports CLASSICAL.
- Key supporting quotes
 - “3 Days Per Week” and “Classical Liberal Arts” with Trivium/Quadrivium framing and guided discussions that aim at truth.
 - “Within the Trivium students move from the concrete to the philosophical through guided discussions that aim at truth. In the Quadrivium students apply mathematical knowledge to the world around us, revealing God’s Creation.”
- Quantitative keyword summary
 - Positive keywords observed: liberal arts, Trivium, Quadrivium, great books/primary sources (implied by classical framework), history/history-education (the structure of Western/Christian civilizational framing is implied by the classical approach).
 - Negative keywords observed: none in public text.
 - Proportion: strong presence of classical curriculum markers.
 - Classification: CLASSICAL.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Pedagogical signals include a mix of contemplative/restful elements and Socratic-like discussion in the Trivium, with guided discussions that aim at truth. The explicit listing of “guided discussions that aim at truth” in the Trivium portion signals some Socratic-style pedagogy, though not necessarily a full, universal Socratic program across all grades.
 - There is no explicit, universal declaration of Socratic seminars or upper-grade rhetoric programs beyond the language of guided discussion and the Trivium/Quadrivium sequence. The lower/upper school pedagogy signals (e.g., singing/recitation or restorative memory practices) are not

described in the Hastings public copy, leaving some aspects of pedagogy under-specified in public materials.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: Socratic/seminar-style thinking is implied through “guided discussions that aim at truth” within the Trivium; emphasis on memory and rhetoric-type elements appears in classical pedagogy lexicon, though not explicitly stated on Hastings pages. The lexicon lists positive pedagogy indicators like Socratic seminar, narration, recitation, chanting, memory work, and rhetoric training as classical signals. Hastings shows some alignment via guided discussions and Trivium/Quadrivium.
 - Negative indicators present: the public copy does not clearly show a full suite of proven classical pedagogy elements (e.g., explicit, systematic Socratic seminars for all grades, or widespread, explicit chanting/memory work). The absence of strong, explicit statements on these items lowers the overall alignment.
- Why this rating
 - The presence of Trivium/Quadrivium and guided discussions suggests some classical pedagogy, but the materials do not provide comprehensive, explicit implementation details for all classical pedagogy signals across grade levels. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.
- Key supporting quotes
 - “Within the Trivium students move from the concrete to the philosophical through guided discussions that aim at truth.”
 - “In the Quadrivium students apply mathematical knowledge to the world around us, revealing God’s Creation ...”
- Quantitative keyword summary
 - Positive keywords observed: guided discussions; truth; Trivium; Quadrivium; classical liberal arts (conceptual equivalence to formal pedagogy).
 - Negative keywords observed: limited explicit statements on full range of classical pedagogy (e.g., explicit Socratic seminars across grades, chanting/memory routines described publicly).
 - Proportion: partial alignment with several classical pedagogy signals, but not a complete, explicit public pedagogy package.
 - Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public materials analyzed emphasize mission, student formation, and curricular structure but provide limited explicit language about the faculty as the living curriculum, mentors, or the “portrait of a teacher” as a core element. The “Join our Faculty” call indicates faculty recruitment, yet there is no explicit public articulation of faculty as “living curriculum” or as the central agents of classical formation in the way the Six Elements template foregrounds.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators (from lexicon): model teachers and mentors; living curriculum; portrait of teacher; faculty of friends; collegial culture; living curriculum; teachers as core of school; character exemplars.
 - Negative indicators present: there is no explicit public text describing these precise faculty-role signals (e.g., living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, or a robust “faculty as core” narrative). The absence of explicit statements reduces classical alignment in this category.
- Why this rating
 - In the absence of explicit, affirmative language about the faculty as the living curriculum or core exemplars, the category cannot be confidently rated CLASSICAL. The text does not provide strong signals aligned with the standard classical faculty indicators.
- Quantitative keyword summary
 - Positive keywords observed: limited (not explicitly stated in public copy as living-curriculum or portrait language).
 - Negative keywords observed: absence of explicit “living curriculum” or “faculty as core” state-

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- ments.
 - Classification: NOT CLASSICAL.
 - Supporting quotes
 - The public pages emphasize mission and structure rather than a faculty-centric articulation. The explicit faculty-living-curriculum language is not present in available text blocks.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Hastings describes a partnership with families and a model where teachers instruct while parents practice with their children, suggesting meaningful parental involvement and a community-oriented model. The “partnership with families” language aligns with classical values of family formation and parental participation.
 - The public copy mentions family practice and time for parents to engage with children in learning. This signals some parent formation and community engagement, though explicit programs for parent education (book studies, gatherings, parent covenant) are not clearly enumerated in the public copy.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive indicators present: partnership with parents; parent formation potential; open campus/-community engagement language is implied by conversations about family-time and practice with children; co-learning with families in the home setting.
 - Negative indicators present: explicit, formal parent-education programs (book studies, formal parent-learning events) are not clearly described in the public copy; the language does not robustly present “parents as co-teachers” or a formal “parent formation” ecosystem.
- Why this rating
 - The school demonstrates a concrete partner-with-parents approach and invites family involvement, which aligns with classical expectations for parent engagement, though it stops short of fully articulating a rich, formal parent-education ecosystem. Thus, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Supporting quotes
 - “This is not a hybrid model where parents are teaching core material but is instead a partnership where the teachers instruct and the parents have time to practice with their children.”
- Quantitative keyword summary
 - Positive keywords observed: partnership with parents; family involvement; parental practice with children.
 - Negative keywords observed: absence of explicit parent-education programs (book groups, parent covenant) in public copy.
 - Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- Explicitly reference and implement Great Books/Great Conversation in curriculum statements, with direct public articulation of a Great Books list or core texts and a public commitment to the Great Conversation as a daily or yearly framework.
- Strengthen Pedagogy language by publicly detailing Socratic seminars across grades, more explicit memory/recitation routines, and a formal “living curriculum” articulation for faculty—position the faculty as the core vehicle of classical formation.
- Expand Visible liturgy/communal practices: articulate morning or weekly liturgical routines, shared prayer, and calendar-based liturgical events to satisfy the Liturgical & Communal Practices criteria.
- Expand Parent Formation: publish concrete families-facing programs (e.g., classical book clubs, teacher-led parent seminars, covenant-style family learning plans) and open sessions to visits and involvement beyond the current partnership framing.
- Make explicit the role of Great Books and primary sources within the curriculum and strengthen the history/Western civ scaffolding as a clearly named pillar.
- Elevate the explicit articulation of the “living curriculum” as a formal concept tied to teacher professional development and student outcomes.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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